

NIKUNJ JAMBU

Conservation Biologist | Spatial Ecologist | MEL Specialist

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Profile

Field ecologist and MEL specialist with 13+ years of experience designing and executing wildlife research, spatial analyses, and monitoring systems across India. Proficient in camera trapping, line transects, acoustic monitoring, habitat assessments, social surveys, and program evaluation. Advanced GIS and quantitative skills (ArcGIS/QGIS, remote sensing, R, PostGIS; Python and Google Earth Engine). Extensive training and stakeholder engagement experience with Forest Departments and local communities.

Education

M.Sc., Zoology (Avian & Wildlife Biology), 2013 — The Maharaja Sayajirao University of Baroda (MSU), Vadodara (66.8%)

B.Sc., Zoology (Hons), 2011 - MSU, Vadodara

B.Sc., Botany, 2009 - MSU, Vadodara

Professional Experience (selected)

MEL Officer — The Nature Conservancy (Current)

- Design MEL frameworks for community conservation, agroforestry, and human–elephant conflict mitigation; integrate Theory of Change and equity.
- Build ArcGIS Survey123 tools and dashboards; translate field & spatial data into decision-ready insights.
- Technical lead for adapting a global Naturebase portal to Indian ecological and social contexts.

Senior Project Manager (Ecologist) — Foundation for Ecological Security (Sep 2020–Mar 2023)

- Scaled the Indian Forest Management Tool (IFMT/VanApp); trained >2,500 forest staff in data collection and working-plan principles.
- Led the revamp of the India Biodiversity Information System (IBIS) portal to current data/taxonomic standards on a GIS engine.
- Conceptualized “Right Tree Right Place” eco-restoration tool using species distribution modelling.

Junior Research Biologist (GIS Analyst) — SACON (Dec 2017–Dec 2019)

- Analysed six decades of LULC change in Sarus Crane habitats across Gujarat; integrated field data with spatial layers.

Project Biologist — Wildlife Institute of India (Jun 2017–Dec 2017)

- Black-necked Crane ecology & e-flow assessment, Nyamjang Chu, Arunachal Pradesh; hydrology and habitat suitability data collection.

Research Associate/Grantee — GIZ CMPA (Dec 2016–Jun 2017)

- Assessed bird–habitat linkages at Khijadiya WLS & Gosabara Wetland; informed wetland management recommendations.

Project Lead — Rufford Small Grants (Jul 2015–Jul 2016)

- Avifaunal conservation in Purna WLS; research, community awareness, and alternative livelihoods (youth bird-guides, ecotourism).

Research Biologist — Wildlife Institute of India (Sep 2013–Jan 2015)

- All India Tiger Estimation: camera traps, line transects, sign surveys; multi-site data collection and analysis.

Research Assistant — Indian Institute of Remote Sensing (May 2009–Jul 2010)

- Biodiversity characterisation using satellite RS & GIS; standardized vegetation plots; herbarium preparation.

Key Skills & Methods

- Field: camera trapping, line transects, sign surveys, acoustic monitoring, habitat assessment, social surveys/FGDs.
- Spatial: ArcGIS, QGIS, remote sensing, SDM, PostGIS, GPS/GNSS; Google Earth Engine (basic).
- Analysis: R (statistical modelling, visualization), Python (basic), SQL; dashboards & workflow automation.
- MEL & Program Evaluation: indicator design, data systems, impact assessment, reporting.

Selected Publications

- Jambu, N. & Patel, K. (2021). Birds of Surat–Dangs: a consolidated checklist of 75 years (1944–2020) with emphasis on noteworthy records and hotspots. *Journal of Threatened Taxa*, 13(7): 18752–18780.
- Maslehuddin, A., Yahya, H., & Jambu, N. (2020). Identification of Warbler species using bioacoustics in Purna Wildlife Sanctuary, Gujarat. *Indian Forester*, 146(10), 924–931.
- Jambu, N. (2020). New record of erythrism in *Eutropis cf. macularia* from Vadodara, Gujarat. *Reptile Rap* #200, *Zoo's Print* 35(6): 03–04.
- Jambu, N. (2019). Territorial fight of Common Krait *Bungarus caeruleus*, Anaikatti Hills, Kerala. *Reptile Rap* #197, *Zoo's Print* 34(12): 19–21.
- Jambu, N. (2017). Avifaunal survey to understand bird–habitat linkages at Khijadiya WLS & Gosabara Wetland. *CMPA Technical Series No. 35*, GIZ India.

Grants, Leadership & Outreach

- Rufford Small Grants (PI), 2015–2016 — Avifaunal conservation in Purna WLS.
- Founder, Dangs Bird Festival (2016–2018) — community-led birding & ecotourism platform with Forest Dept. partnership.
- Core Organizing Team, Young Ecologists Talk & Interact (YETI) 2018.

Selected Certifications

- [Career Essentials in Data Analysis by Microsoft and LinkedIn](#)
- [15 Days of SQL: The Complete SQL Masterclass 2025](#)
- [Data Analytics in R](#)
- [A Comprehensive Guide to PostGIS and Spatial Queries](#)
- [Python in 5 Weeks](#)
- [Data Science Essentials](#)
- [Data Science With SQL and Tableau](#)
- [End-to-End Google Earth Engine](#)